SALVAGE RUN

A portrait space roguelite: launch, blast through a sector, grab salvage, and decide whether to jump deeper or go home

10–12 MINUTE RUNS · AUTO-FIRE · RISK / RETURN · PORTRAIT

Design goal

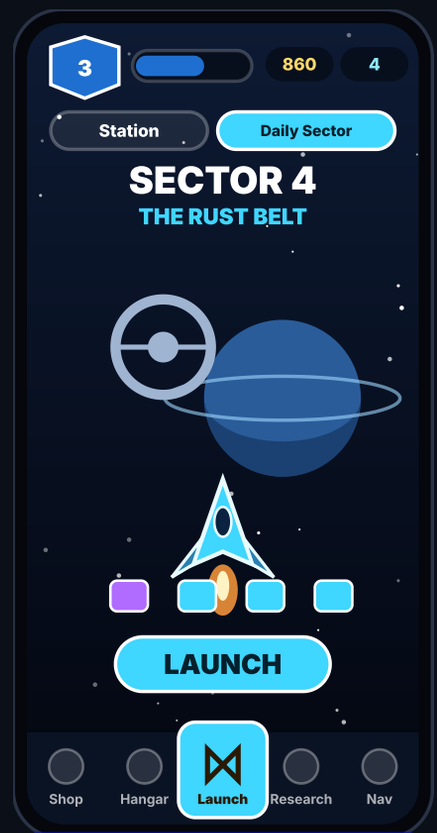
Build ridiculous ship synergies with minimal controls.

Get the feel of exploring space without building a giant space game.

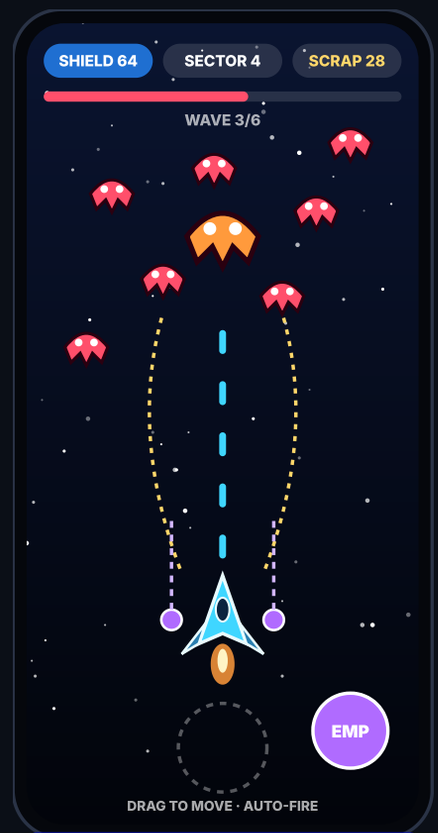
Reading Key

This edition keeps the original brief's ideas and adds detail:

- Untagged: from the original brief
- SUGGESTED My addition or fix, for you to accept or reject
- SOURCED Checked against a cited source (page 8)
- All art is placeholder SVG drawn for this brief



Station hub: one big LAUNCH button



Run screen: drag to evade, weapons auto-fire

Loop

Launch · Engage · Upgrade · Salvage · Return (p.2–3)

Meta

The station and its 4 modules (p.4)

Economy & store

Three resources, light monetization (p.5–6)

MVP & research

What to build first, and why (p.7–8)

1. CORE LOOP

Launch. Fight. Salvage. Decide.

LAUNCH Pick ship › **ENGAGE** Short battle › **UPGRADE** 1 of 3 modules › **SALVAGE** Collect scrap › **DECIDE** Jump or return › **RETURN** Bank rewards

A small game that feels like part of a much bigger universe.

Why it works

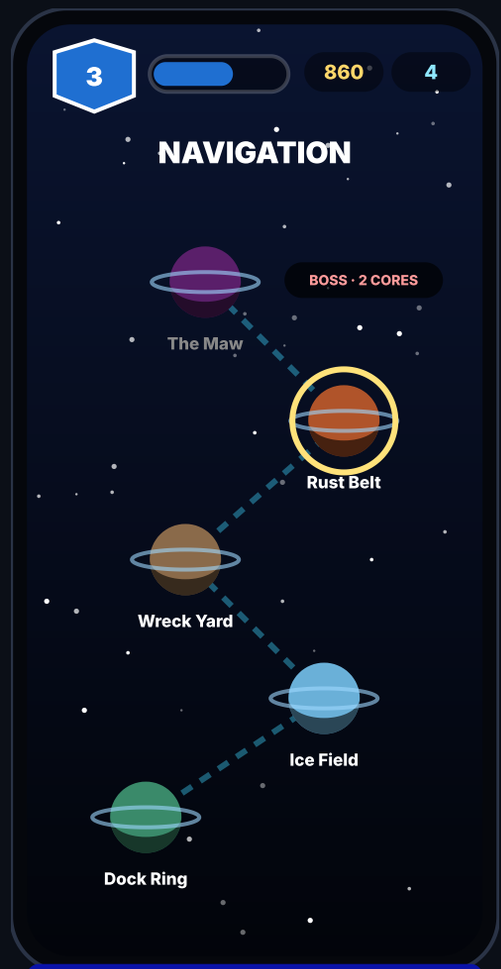
- Ship builds are easy to read at a glance
- The space theme naturally supports modular upgrades
- Risk/return gives each run tension

Prototype rule

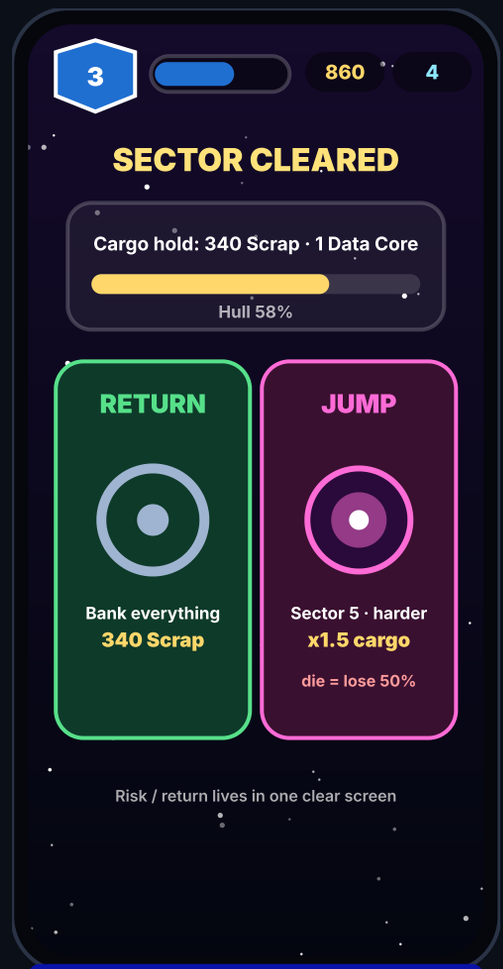
No open-world exploration. "Space" is a sequence of compact encounters: each sector is 6 waves, a boss, then a decision.

SUGGESTED Make risk/return a real screen

The original lists 'risk/return' as a pillar but never shows where it happens. Proposal: after each sector boss, **Jump** (next sector harder, cargo x1.5, die and lose 50%) or **Return** (bank everything). One screen, one decision.



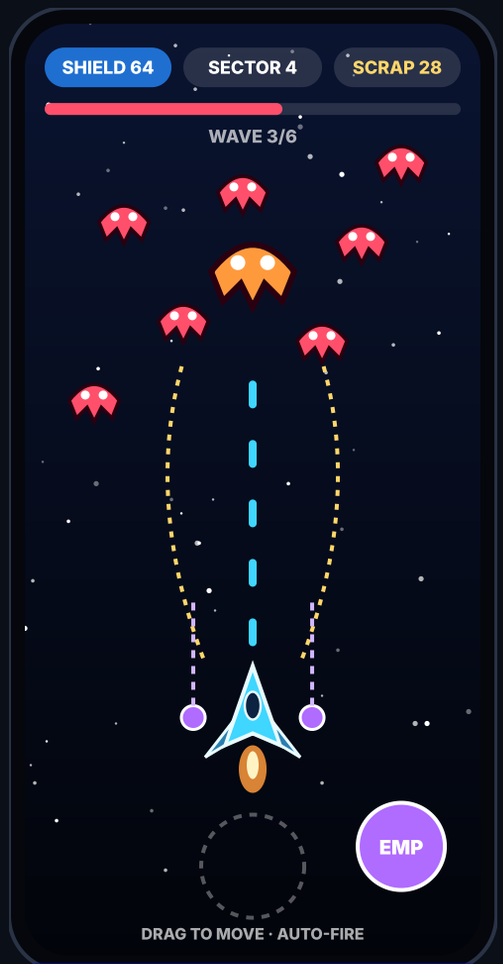
Sectors are chapter nodes, not a star map



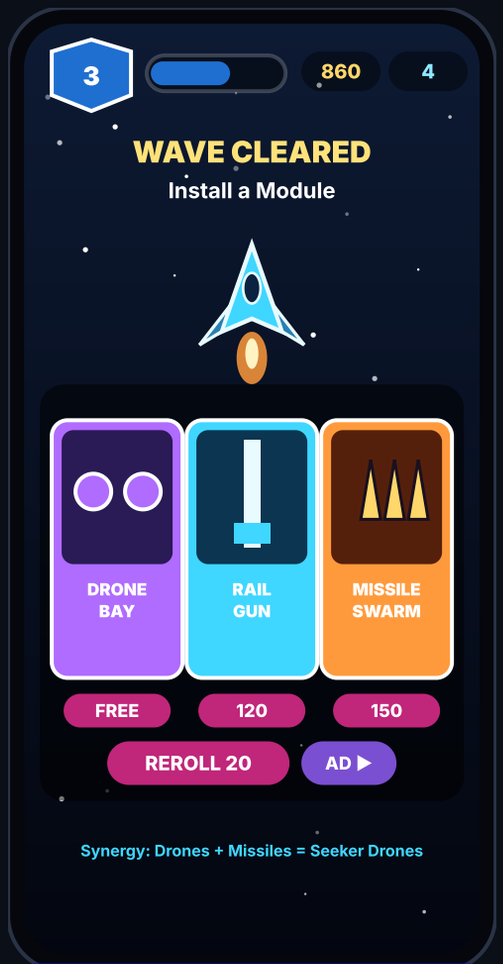
Jump or Return: the risk/return beat

2. RUN SCREEN

Minimal Control. Maximum Build Expression.



Run screen: drag to evade, weapons auto-fire



Module pick: 1 of 3, shows synergies

Moving the ship matters, but the spectacle comes from upgrade combinations.

Moment-to-moment

- Drag the ship to evade; it never needs a fire button
- Weapons auto-fire
- One active ability on a cooldown (e.g. EMP)
- Short enemy waves of about 40–60 seconds

Build examples

- **Drone carrier**: orbiting drones that each fire their own shots
- **Crit missile swarm**: crits launch homing missiles
- **Piercing railgun**: one slow beam that hits a whole column
- **Shield retaliation**: absorbing damage fires a nova

SUGGESTED Show synergies on the card

Module cards should name their combos ("Drones + Missiles = Seeker Drones"). That's how builds become 'ridiculous' without a codex.

3. META LOOP

The Station Is the Home Screen.

Permanent upgrades unlock new build directions instead of just raising stats.

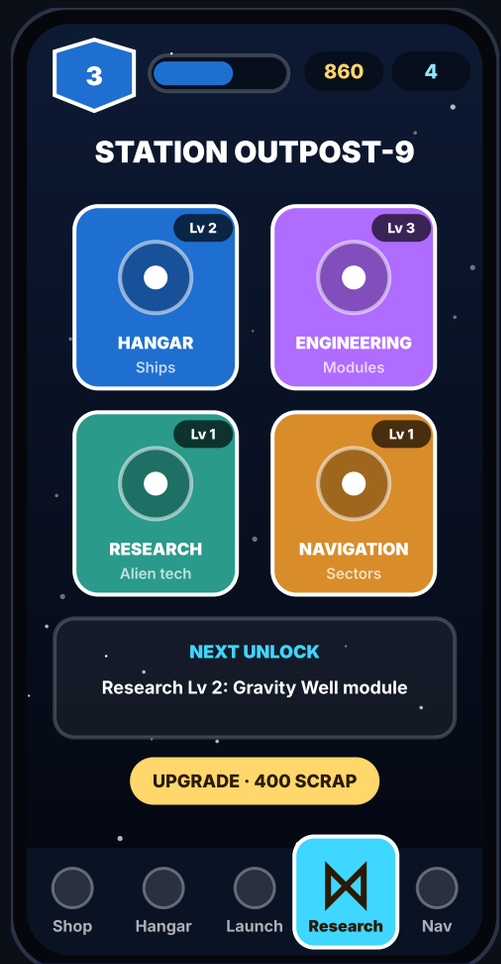
Hangar
Ships: 4 archetypes, each starting from a different build.

Engineering
Modules: adds new cards to the upgrade pool.

Research
Alien tech: rare, game-changing modules (needs Data Cores).

Navigation
Sectors: unlocks the next chapter node and its modifiers.

Launch scope
- 1 station screen
- 4 ship archetypes max
- No trading simulation
- No large star map; sectors are chapter nodes



Station: 4 modules unlock build options



Hangar: 4 ship archetypes, earned in play

4. ECONOMY

Keep the Economy Readable.

The player should understand every resource on sight.

Scrap

- Earned every run
- Station upgrades
- Main progression currency

Data Cores

- Bosses / anomalies
- Unlock ships and advanced tech
- Rare progression

Credits (optional)

- Premium / rewarded
- Cosmetics and rerolls
- Not required to progress

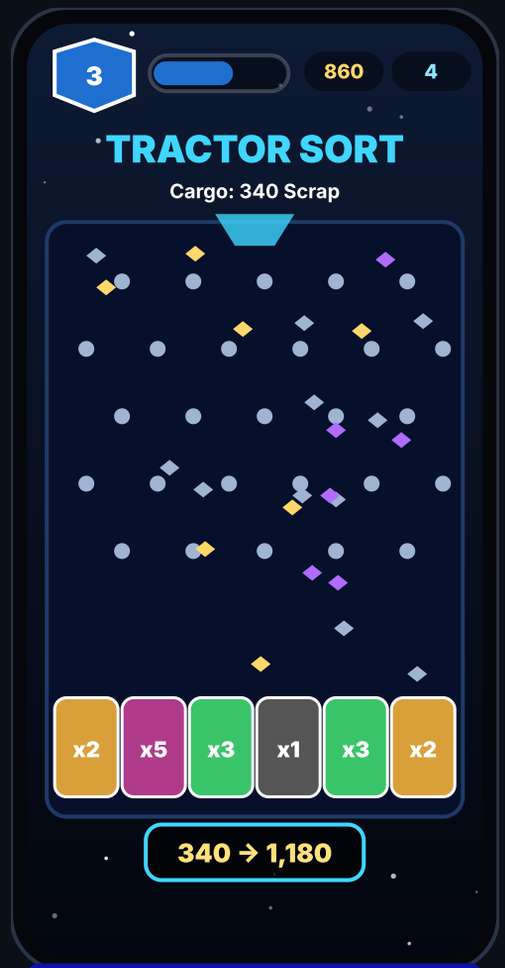
Retention

- Daily sector
- Weekly anomaly
- Ship mastery
- Rotating cosmetic

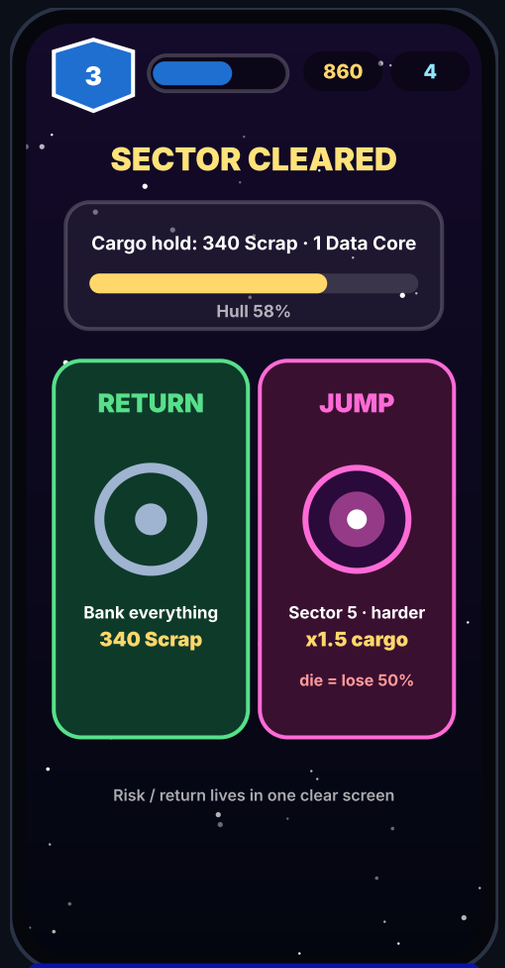
Avoid

- Fuel timers
- Lootbox ships
- Too many material types
- Aggressive timed bundles

SUGGESTED **Drop Credits entirely** and price cosmetics in dollars, which leaves 2 currencies. A premium currency is the first step toward Cup Heroes-style exchange-rate pressure. SUGGESTED **Tractor Sort** (right) is a tactile cargo multiplier; Space Rock Breaker already pairs space mining with a Plinko board (page 8).



Tractor Sort: a Plinko board for cargo



Jump or Return: the risk/return beat

5. MONETIZATION

Monetize Lightly. Keep the Game First.

A compact model inspired by mobile roguelites, without Cup Heroes-level pressure.

1 · Rewarded Ads *optional*

Revive, reroll or reward boost. The player chooses the moment. SUGGESTED
Cap them at about 3 per run.

2 · One-Time Support Pack $3.99–$5.99

No forced ads, a cosmetic and starter currency.

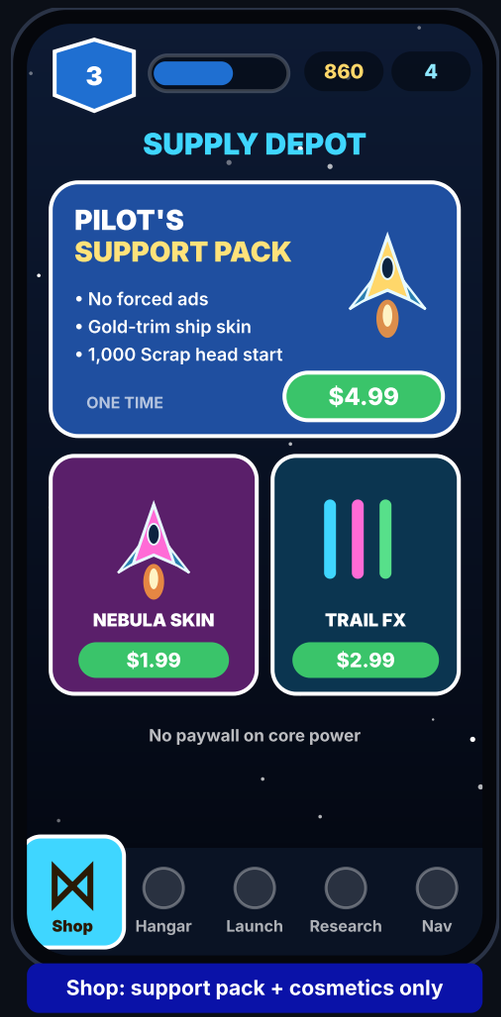
3 · Cosmetics $1.99–$4.99

Ship skins, trail effects, visual themes.

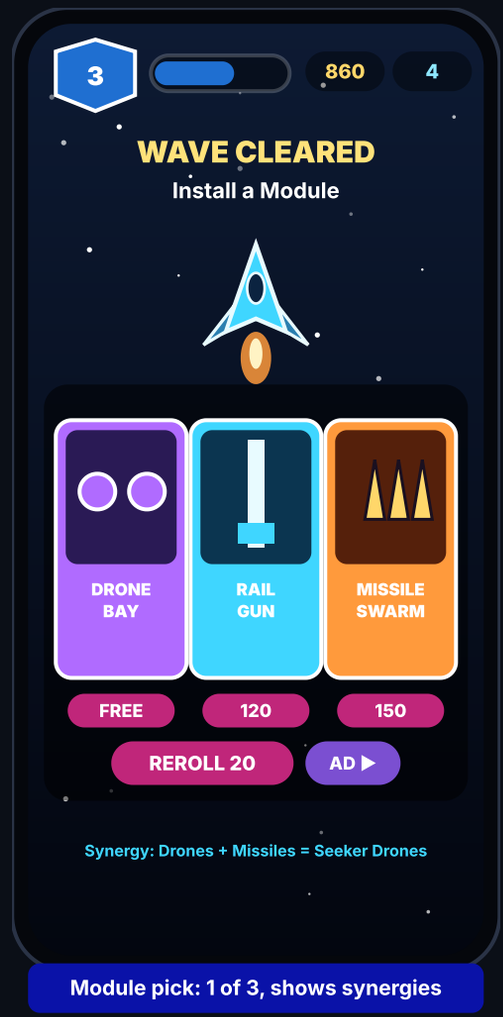
4 · Later: Mini Pass $4.99 / season

Only after retention is proven. SUGGESTED Keep the premium track cosmetic.

RULE: NO PAYWALL ON CORE POWER



Shop: support pack + cosmetics only



Module pick: 1 of 3, shows synergies

6. MVP

Small Enough to Actually Finish.

The prototype's job is to prove the loop before any content pipeline exists. SUGGESTED **The list below is ship-specific (the original repeated the same list in both briefs).**

Build First

- 1 ship (Interceptor)
- 1 sector (Rust Belt) of 6 waves
- 8–10 modules, including 2 synergy pairs
- 3 enemy archetypes: swarmer, shooter, tank
- 1 boss encounter
- The Jump / Return screen
- 1 station screen with 2 working modules

Add After Fun

- 3 more ships (Carrier, Lancer, Bastion)
- 2 more sectors
- Daily sector + weekly anomaly
- Tractor Sort multiplier
- Cosmetics
- Rewarded ads
- Support pack

Do Not Build Yet

- Guilds
- PvP
- Dozens of ships
- Complex crafting
- Large battle pass
- Live economy events
- An open star map

TARGET: A PLAYABLE LOOP BEFORE A CONTENT PIPELINE

SUGGESTED **A clear pass/fail test for the prototype:** does picking a module change how you move within 2 waves? If not, the builds aren't expressive enough, and more content won't fix that.

7. RESEARCH ANCHORS

Why Space Made the Cut (and What's Unproven)

StarVaders

SOURCED Released April 2025 on PC. Steam: **Overwhelmingly Positive**, ~3.7K reviews across languages in snapshots I found. A compact sci-fi roguelite deckbuilder.

Space Rock Breaker

SOURCED $2.99 on Steam (Dec 2025). Mine asteroids, **process ore through a Plinko machine**, upgrade. Rated Overwhelmingly Positive in one listing. A September 2026 article reports a **mobile version in pre-registration**.

Sensor Tower: State of Gaming 2026

SOURCED Mobile game IAP revenue reached **$82B** in 2025 (+1%). Most of it goes to the top 1% of publishers (92.5% of IAP revenue).

Corrections to the original brief: it cites StarVaders at '93%+ with 4K+ reviews'. The snapshots I found show ~3.7K reviews and up to 98% positive, so the direction holds but I'd quote it as 'Overwhelmingly Positive'. Space Rock Breaker is a stronger anchor than the original says: it's small, cheap, space-themed, uses a Plinko reward board, and is moving to mobile.

The gap: all of these are **PC/Steam** signals. In my earlier research I found **no mobile revenue data for space roguelites**. Treat space as the less-proven of the two directions on mobile, and let a prototype or an early store test answer it.

1. Steam store: StarVaders
   https://store.steampowered.com/app/2417280/
2. OpenCritic: StarVaders reviews
   https://opencritic.com/game/18471/-/reviews
3. Automaton: Space Rock Breaker launch (Plinko ore processing)
   https://automaton-media.com/articles/newsjp/space-rock-breaker-20251224-388202/
4. MuMu Player: Space Rock Breaker details
   https://www.mumuplayer.com/blog/space-rock-breaker-release-date.html
5. Sensor Tower: State of Gaming 2026 press release
   https://sensortower.com/press/press-release-sensor-tower-state-of-gaming-gaming-drove-52-billion-downloads-82b-iap-revenue-on-mobile-and-12b-premium-revenue-on-steam
6. Adapty: Soul Knight IAP pricing estimate
   https://adapty.io/paywall-library/soul-knight/